

Friday 6 October 2023

Meeting Communiqué

Commonwealth, state, and territory agriculture ministers met virtually on Friday 6 October 2023, for the third and final Agriculture Ministers' Meeting (AMM) of the year.

AMM 03/2023 was chaired by the Australian Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Senator the Hon Murray Watt. Minister Watt welcomed the new AMM member for Victoria, the Hon Ros Spence MP and thanked the Hon Gayle Tierney MLC for her work during her time as Minister for Agriculture in Victoria.

Seasonal conditions and livestock and food prices

Ministers noted the meeting was taking place at a time of deteriorating seasonal conditions over much of Australia, impending drought and natural disasters and expectations of a decreased winter crop harvest.

Ministers noted that these conditions were contributing to sharply declining livestock prices impacting farming businesses, their families and regional communities. Ministers encouraged the consideration in forthcoming Commonwealth competition reviews of the impact of competition on commodity, food and grocery prices.

ABARES Farm Performance Report

ABARES updated forecasts for farm financial performance were discussed, it was noted that due to drier conditions and lower commodity prices significant falls in income are expected in many parts of regional Australia.

Climate smart agriculture

Ministers provided updates on the work underway in their jurisdictions to progress their commitments under the National Statement on Climate Change and Agriculture.

Minister Watt provided an update on the development of the Agriculture and Land Plan, 1 of 6 sectoral decarbonisation plans being developed to guide Australia's transition to a net zero economy by 2050. The plan will explore pathways for emissions reduction in the sector, with government and industry stakeholders working collaboratively to chart an achievable path for the sector's contribution to a net zero economy. Ministers welcomed the opportunity to contribute to the development of the Plan during the upcoming consultation period.

Ministers noted an update from the Australian Energy Infrastructure Commissioner, Mr Andrew Dyer, on the Community Engagement Review into community support and social license for renewable energy generation and transmission projects. Ministers discussed that the expansion of transmission infrastructure has implications for agricultural stakeholders, and that proper consultation and

information sharing is required to ensure that the concerns of affected coastal and inland communities are addressed. The Review Final Report will provide advice on maximising community engagement with and benefit from these projects and will be delivered to the Minister for Climate Change and Energy by the end of 2023.

Ministers shared key priorities and initiatives in their jurisdictions to empower and support First Nations people with the management of their land, sea and country. Ministers noted that governments, at all levels, have a role to play in both leadership and action to include First Nations people in agriculture, fisheries and forestry. They agreed to task AGSOC to work in consultation with First Nations peoples to identify opportunities to increase meaningful involvement of First Nations people in agriculture, fisheries and forestry.

Red Imported Fire Ants

Minister Furner gave an update on the ongoing eradication efforts under the National Fire Ant Eradication Program (NFAEP). Ministers noted the progress of the workplan and reaffirmed their commitment to eradicating red imported fire ants (RIFA) from all of Australia.

Minister Watt emphasised the importance of a sustained national response to this insidious pest, and welcomed the progress in bringing forward future year budget allocations to support eradication efforts centred on south-east Queensland this year. To align the NFAEP with other major biosecurity responses, Ministers committed to the forward response plan being delivered under enhanced governance arrangements overseen by all states and territories.

Ministers remain unified on the need to continue to eradicate and affirmed their commitment to work through their Budget processes.

Lumpy skin disease

Ministers noted the strong collaboration all relevant jurisdictions that assisted in resolving Indonesia and Malaysia's recent decisions to suspend live cattle exports from Australia. Ministers noted that Australia remains free of lumpy skin disease and that live exports to Indonesia and Malaysia had now resumed.

Varroa mite

Ministers noted the ongoing challenge of varroa mite and the recent decision of the government and industry led National Management Group that eradication of varroa destructor (varroa mite) is no longer technically feasible to eradicate and the response should now transition to a management strategy. Ministers expressed their ongoing interest in the specifics of these transitional arrangements and recognised the efforts of NSW as the lead jurisdiction in this national response.

National Biosecurity Strategy

Ministers discussed the importance of the National Biosecurity Strategy (NBS) and its implementation. Ministers will consider the final NBS Implementation Plan in early November 2023.

National Carp Control Plan

Ministers agreed to progress work for the priority actions identified in the National Carp Control Plan to determine if the virus is safe, effective and feasible. These priority actions address the range of uncertainties raised in the National Carp Control Plan.

Ministers noted progress for national implementation of mandatory electronic identification (eID) for sheep and goats, working towards 1 January 2025. Ministers discussed the current challenges posed by emerging market and environmental conditions, while recognising the importance of implementing this national reform to enhance Australia's national livestock traceability arrangements and address emerging risks.

Ministers remain committed to implementation timeframes and noted the significant funding and effort from all Australian Governments, with approximately \$130 million announced to date.

Intergovernmental Agreement on Biosecurity

Ministers noted the requirement for commencement of an independent review of the Intergovernmental Agreement on Biosecurity in early 2024 and discussed preparations and its terms of reference.

Animal welfare

Ministers were advised work is underway by the Animal Welfare Task Group on the staged approach for improving national standards and guidelines for animal welfare as discussed at AMM 02/2023. The Animal Welfare Task Group is also continuing work towards a national approach for greater transparency on animal welfare incidents. AMM will receive a further update on both of these matters in early 2024.

Agriculture workforce

Minister Watt gave an update on the final meeting and achievements from the 12-month tripartite Agricultural Workforce Working Group. Key outcomes from the advocacy of the working group included:

- fee-free TAFE places for agriculture, with over 9,500 enrolments in agriculture related courses over the first half of 2023;
- the Ag Trade Apprenticeship Project being led by Skills Insight, the Agribusiness Jobs and Skills Council;
- a food supply chain capacity study, to be delivered by Jobs and Skills Australia; and

- employer group and union agreement on principles underpinning labour hire licensing.

Minister Watt outlined that tripartite engagement on agricultural workforce issues will continue through an Agricultural Workforce Forum.

Next meeting

The AMM's meeting schedule for 2024 is being finalised.

Ministerial attendees

- Australian Government (Chair): Senator the Hon Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry and Minister for Emergency Management
- Australian Capital Territory: Rebecca Vassarotti MLA, Minister for the Environment
- New South Wales: Hon Tara Moriarty MLC, Minister for Agriculture, Minister for Regional New South Wales and Minister for Western New South Wales
- Northern Territory: Hon Paul Kirby MLA, Minister for Agribusiness and Fisheries
- Queensland: Hon Mark Furner MP, Minister for Agricultural Industry Development and Fisheries
- South Australia: Hon Clare Scriven MLC, Minister for Primary Industries and Regional Development
- Tasmania: Hon Jo Palmer MLC, Minister for Primary Industries and Water
- Victoria: Hon Ros Spence MP, Minister for Agriculture
- Western Australia: Hon Jackie Jarvis MLC, Minister for Agriculture and Food

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-ministers-forum-oct-2023>